

Make routine work move by itself.

Today we learn how automation tools like Zapier connect apps, move information, send reminders, and reduce repetitive copy-paste work.

Automation

Zapier

Triggers

Actions

Useful workflow

Final output

A mapped workflow, one simple automation plan, and a tested Zapier-style build checklist.

 CORE IDEA

Repeats a rule

When something happens, the automation follows a prepared instruction.

Moves information

It can copy details between forms, spreadsheets, email, calendars, and task tools.

Starts a next step

It can notify a person, create a task, save a file, or ask for approval.

Simple definition: automation is a workflow that runs without you manually doing every click.

If it is repeated, predictable, and low-risk, it may be a good automation candidate

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Zapier is a connector between apps.

It lets non-programmers create workflows called Zaps. A Zap watches one app for an event, then performs one or more actions in other apps.

No-code builder

App connectors

Multi-step workflows

Testing tools

Example

1. A parent submits a Google Form.
2. Zapier detects the new response.
3. It adds a row to a tracking sheet.
4. It sends a confirmation email.
5. It creates a follow-up task for staff.

● ● ● AUTOMATION WORDS YOU NEED

Trigger

The event that starts the workflow, such as a new form response.

Action

What happens next, such as send email, add row, or create task.

Zap

Zapier's name for one automation workflow.

Step

One trigger or action inside a workflow.

Filter

A rule that lets the workflow continue only when conditions are true.

Path

A branch that sends different cases to different actions.

Field

A piece of data, such as name, email, class, amount, or date.

Test

A trial run that checks whether each step behaves correctly.

Trigger

New Google Form response arrives.



Action 1

Add the details to a Google Sheet.



Action 2

Send a confirmation email or staff alert.

Automation sentence: When this happens, do this, then do this.

● ● ● WHAT SHOULD WE AUTOMATE?

Form follow-up

Send confirmations and collect responses in one sheet.

Task creation

Create to-dos from emails, forms, or project updates.

Calendar reminders

Create calendar events from approved requests.

File organization

Rename, move, or notify when a file is uploaded.

Communication

Send alerts to email, Slack, Teams, or another channel.

Reporting

Collect activity into a dashboard or weekly summary.

Start with one small workflow that saves real time

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● ● ● AUTOMATION TOOL FAMILIES

Tool	Best fit	Watch for
Zapier	Beginner-friendly app connections and quick no-code workflows.	Plan limits, app permissions, and task usage.
Make.com	Visual scenario builder for more detailed branching workflows.	Can feel more technical for new users.
Microsoft Power Automate	Organizations already using Microsoft 365, Teams, SharePoint, or Outlook.	Account and admin permissions matter.
n8n	Technical teams wanting more control or self-hosting.	Setup and maintenance require skill.
Google Apps Script	Custom Google Sheets, Docs, Forms, and Gmail workflows.	Requires scripting and careful testing.

Tool features, pricing, and limits change. Check the account before class.

● ● ● **BEFORE YOU CONNECT APPS**

Private data

Do not send student records, personal IDs, health data, or confidential client details unless policy allows it.

Permissions

Know which account owns the automation and which apps it can read or write.

Human approval

Keep approvals for payments, grades, discipline, hiring, public posts, and sensitive messages.

Audit trail

Keep a simple record of what the automation changes and where errors are logged.

Testing data

Test with sample records before using real names, emails, or official documents.

Owner

Assign a person to maintain, pause, or repair the workflow when something changes.

● ● ● CHOOSE YOUR FIRST AUTOMATION

Repeated

It happens often enough that saving time matters.

Predictable

The steps are clear and usually follow the same rule.

Low-risk

A mistake would be easy to notice and repair.

WORKFLOW SELECTION PROMPT Help me choose a safe beginner automation from these repeated tasks:

[PASTE TASK LIST]

For each task, score:

1. How repeated it is.
2. How predictable it is.
3. How risky it is.
4. What human review should remain.
5. Whether Zapier is a good fit.

Recommend the safest first workflow and explain why.

Scenario

A school collects workshop registrations through a Google Form. Staff want a clean tracker and automatic confirmation message.

Trigger: new form response

Action: add row

Action: send email

Fields to map

1. Name.
2. Email.
3. Role or class.
4. Preferred session.
5. Question or note.
6. Submission timestamp.

Scenario

Important emails with a specific label should become follow-up tasks so they do not disappear in the inbox.

Trigger: labeled email

Filter: from approved sender

Action: create task

Good task title

TEMPLATE Follow up: {{Email Subject}}

Due: tomorrow

Notes:

- Sender: {{From Name}}
- Summary: {{Email Snippet}}
- Link: {{Email Link}}

COPY-READY PLANNING PROMPT Act as a workflow automation coach.

I want to automate:
[TASK]

Apps involved:
[APP 1, APP 2, APP 3]

Current manual steps:
[LIST STEPS]

Data fields:
[LIST FIELDS]

Risks or private information:
[LIST RISKS]

Create a beginner-friendly automation plan:

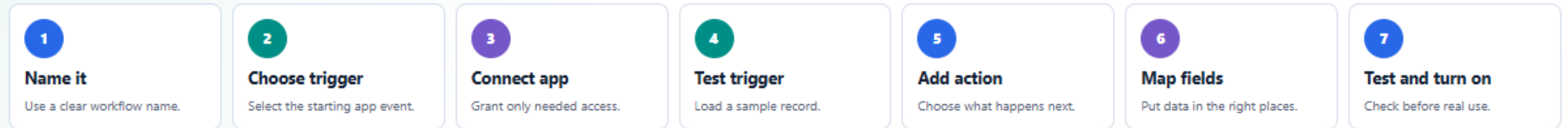
1. Trigger.
2. Required app connections.
3. Action steps.
4. Field mapping table.
5. Filters or approval points.
6. Test cases.
7. What should remain human-reviewed.
8. A simple rollback plan if something goes wrong.

Why this helps

1. Names the trigger clearly.
2. Prevents missing fields.
3. Surfaces privacy concerns.
4. Creates test cases first.
5. Keeps approval where needed.

Copy planning prompt

Follow the same pattern every time.



● ● ● **MAKE AUTOMATIONS SMARTER**

Filter

Continue only if the form answer says "urgent" or the email comes from an approved address.

Formatter

Clean dates, names, phone numbers, text, or numbers before sending them onward.

Path

Send high-priority requests to one action and normal requests to another action.

Beginner rule: build the basic version first. Add filters, formatting, and branches only when the simple Zap works.

● ● ● TESTING CHECKLIST

Happy path

A normal record moves through every step correctly.

Missing field

The workflow behaves safely when a name, email, date, or category is blank.

Wrong condition

Filters stop records that should not continue.

Duplicate

The workflow does not create repeated tasks or emails by mistake.

Permission

The owner account can still access every connected app.

Recipient check

Messages go only to intended people, with correct subject and body.

Common causes

1. App password or permission changed.
2. Column name changed in a spreadsheet.
3. Field mapped into the wrong place.
4. Filter condition is too strict.
5. Tool plan or usage limit was reached.
6. The app changed its interface or API.

Repair habit

1. Read the error message.
2. Find the failing step.
3. Retest that step with sample data.
4. Fix one thing at a time.
5. Run a full end-to-end test.
6. Write down what changed.

Document the workflow

1. Workflow name and purpose.
2. Owner and backup owner.
3. Connected apps and accounts.
4. Trigger and actions.
5. Fields being moved.
6. Risks and review points.
7. How to pause or repair it.

SOP PROMPT Create a one-page standard operating procedure for this automation:

[PASTE WORKFLOW]

Include:

- Purpose.
- Owner.
- Trigger.
- Actions.
- Data fields.
- Privacy notes.
- Test checklist.
- What to do if it fails.

Write it so a new staff member can understand it.

Required output

1. Automation sentence.
2. Workflow diagram.
3. Trigger and action list.
4. Field mapping table.
5. Safety notes.
6. Three test cases.
7. One-page SOP.

Time: 60 minutes

Build options

1. Build a simple Zap if accounts are ready.
2. Simulate the workflow on paper if account access blocks you.
3. Use screenshots or a table to show each step.
4. Present the risk and review point clearly.

 FACILITATOR VIEW | DAY 18 SCHEDULE

Time	Block	Visible output
00:00-00:25	Automation concept, Zapier vocabulary, and examples	Automation sentence
00:25-00:50	Choose safe workflow and map trigger/actions	Workflow diagram
00:50-01:15	Safety, permissions, and field mapping	Risk notes and field table
01:15-01:25	Break	Reset
01:25-02:10	Build or simulate the Zapier workflow	Draft automation
02:10-02:45	Test cases, filters, and troubleshooting	Test report
02:45-02:55	Break	Reset
02:55-03:25	Write one-page SOP and maintenance notes	Automation SOP
03:25-04:00	Peer review and 60-second showcase	Ready workflow plan

Good automation is simple, tested, documented, and still human-owned.

Trigger

Action

Field mapping

Filters

Testing

SOP

Print / Save PDF

Exit ticket

1. What workflow did you choose?
2. What starts the automation?
3. Which field mapping matters most?
4. What should remain human-reviewed?
5. How will you test before using real data?